Mobility protocol — upper body (hEDS / HSD safe)

Pre: joint control before warm-up sets · Post: joint check · active drills only (R7) · add-ons by target

Target area — dashed cards are add-ons

Shoulder / cuff · Scapula / upper back · Elbow / arms · Wrist / spine · Breathing

⚠ Why active drills only — hEDS / HSD

Your joints have range to spare; what they lack is control. Muscles guard loose joints with protective tension, and passive stretching switches that guard off. Every drill here is made by your own muscles, inside the range they control, with nothing pushing further (R7).

PRE-WORKOUT — joint control (core ~10 min · before warm-up sets)

Core: every upper-body joint, every session · Add-ons: pick by your session's targets · light effort, slow breathing

Core — every session

P1 Shoulder CARs, both arms together — 2 each direction
Shoulder capsule · rotator cuff · scapular stabilisers — ~30 s per circle
Arms circle together, mirrored: the biggest circle you control (R12) — standing
Steady tension, short of end range; ribs down, low back still (R1 · R3)

P2 Band external-rotation hold, 3 angles, both hands on one band — 8 s × 3 angles
Infraspinatus · teres minor · back of the cuff — × 2 rounds
Elbows pinned to your sides; turn both forearms out against the band — light band
Hold near neutral, mid-way, then at ~70–80% of your turn-out — 90° only if it's inside (R1)

P3 Internal-rotation hold, both arms, palms pressed together — 8 s hold
Subscapularis · front of the cuff (front-of-shoulder stability) — × 3
Elbows pinned to your sides, bent 90°; hands meet in front of the belly — no kit
Press palm into palm ~20–30%: both shoulders turn in against each other, nothing moves

P4 Band pull-apart hold at chest height — 2 × 8 reps
Rear delts · rhomboids · mid-trap; the chest lengthens actively — 3 s hold each rep
Hands stop in line with the shoulders, never behind the torso (R1) — light band
Elbows soft (R2); shoulder blades come together without a shrug (R8)

P5 Wrist CARs, both wrists together + palm press in 4 directions — 5 circles each way
Wrist capsule · forearm flexors and extensors — + 5 s × 4 directions
Forearms on your thighs; both wrists circle slowly, ~70–80% of range — seated
Then palm into palm: bend up · bend down · thumb side · little-finger side, ~20–30% each

P6 Scapular push-up hold (on fists or DB handles) — 3 × 10 s hold
Serratus anterior · lower trap · elbow control — knees down if needed
Wrists straight on fists or hex DB handles, never bent back (R2)
Push the shoulder blades apart to ~80% and hold; elbows soft, ~15° short of straight (R1 · R2)

P7 Wrist weight shifts on fists, 4 directions (hands and knees) — 5 s × 4 directions
Wrist stabilisers in neutral · forearm co-contraction — × 2 rounds
On fists or DB handles, knees down; wrists stay straight throughout
Shift a little forward · back · left · right and hold each; no bend at the wrist (R1 · R2)

P8 Cat-cow with pauses (on fists or DB handles) — 1 × 6 reps
Thoracic spine · serratus · rhomboids · deep core — 3 s pause each end
Low back moves only part-way: your stage-1 range, short of each end (R3)
Pause 3 s near each end: cat = push the floor away · cow = blades together, no sag

Add-ons — pick by your session's targets

P9 Prone Y-T-W holds — 1 round
Lower and mid trap · rhomboids · back of the cuff — overhead days — 8 s each letter
Face down, chest on the floor, thumbs up; no shrug (R8) — body weight
Y short of end range · T at the shoulder line · W with the arms angled, not spread wide (R1)

P10 Overhead triceps hold, both arms (band under both feet) — 2 × 12 s hold
Triceps long head · overhead control — before overhead extensions — light band
Shoulder blades braced overhead, arms short of end range (R6 · R1)
Elbows bend to ~70–80% and hold; nothing pulls the arms deeper (R7)

P11 Seated thoracic rotation, arms crossed — 5 each side
Upper-back rotation · obliques — slow
Sit tall on the bench, arms crossed on the chest, pelvis still
Turn the upper back to ~70–80% of the range and pause 2 s; no bounce (R1 · R7)

P12 Neck rotation holds, both hands resisting — 5 s each way
Neck stabilisers — when the neck feels stiff — × 2 rounds
Both hands stacked on the side of the head; turn into them ~20%
The head stays still; the hands only resist, never push the head further (R7)

POST-WORKOUT — joint check and wind-down (core ~4 min · after the last set)

Compare each joint with the pre half · log any change with the step gate (§2.6) · tightness → foam rolling (R7)

Core — every session

S1 Shoulder CARs, slow scan, both arms together — 1 each direction
Joint check: compare with P1 — ~45 s per circle
One slow circle each way; note any new catch, click or looseness
Worse than in P1 → note it in the step-gate log; a loose shoulder ends the drill (§2.6 · R9)

S2 Wrist CARs, slow scan, both wrists together — 3 each direction
Joint check: compare with P5 — seated
Forearms on your thighs; 3 slow circles each way, ~70–80% of range
New catching or pain compared with P5 → note it in the step-gate log (§2.6)

S3 90/90 breathing (feet on the bench or wall) — 5 breaths
Diaphragm · deep core — winding down — 4 s in / 8 s out
On your back, hips and knees at 90°, feet resting on the bench — ~1 min
Breathe in 4 s through the nose, ribs widen · out 8 s, ribs drop; easy, unforced

Add-ons — when your session calls for them

S4 Prone Y-T-W holds — 1 round
Lower and mid trap · back of the cuff — after a session without the Y raise — 8 s each letter
As P9: chest on the floor, thumbs up, no shrug (R8) — body weight
Y short of end range · T at the shoulder line · W with the arms angled, not spread wide (R1)

S5 Overhead triceps hold, both arms (band under both feet) — 2 × 12 s hold
Triceps long head — if they feel tight; foam rolling first (R7) — light band
As P10: shoulder blades braced overhead, arms short of end range (R6)
Elbows bend to ~70–80% and hold; nothing pulls the arms deeper (R7)

S6 Biceps hold, both palms pressing forward (uprights or doorway) — 2 × 15 s hold
Biceps · brachialis — if tight after curls; foam rolling first (R7) — uprights or doorway
Facing the rack uprights or a doorway: palms forward against them, arms at your sides (R5)
Elbows at ~140–150°; press forward ~30% and hold, both arms together (R1 · R12)

Holds: breathe in before, breathe out slowly during — never hold your breath
A slow exhale under tension keeps trunk pressure steady

Target index — what each drill prepares; pick add-ons by your session

Shoulder capsule / cuff	P1 · P2 · P3 · post S1
Scapula / upper back	P4 · P6 · P8 · add-on P9 · post S4
Chest / front of shoulder	P3 · P4 (chest lengthens) · P6
Lats / overhead work	P1 · add-ons P9 · P10
Elbow · biceps · triceps	P6 (soft elbow) · add-on P10 · post S5 · S6 · your warm-up sets
Wrist · forearm · grip	P5 · P7 · post S2
Upper and lower back	P8 · add-on P11
Neck	add-on P12
Ribcage / winding down	post S3

Before vs after — log any change with the step gate (§2.6)

- Shoulders: S1 vs P1 — any new click, catch or looseness?
- Wrists: S2 vs P5 — any new catching or pain?
- Worse after a drill → log it and leave that drill out next session

Every drill, every session — hEDS / HSD rules

- Active only: your own muscles move and hold; nothing pushes a joint further, no bounce (R7)
- ~70–80% of your range, never end range; a soft bend at every joint, no lockout (R1 · R2)
- CARs: a spot catches or clicks → slow down there, never force through it (R7)
- Both arms together on every drill: one-arm work waits for loading stage 3 (R12)
- Spine at stage 1: the low back moves only part-way, ribs down (R3)
- Light: holds at ~20–30% of a max push, moves slow and smooth — drills are not working sets (§2.3 · R19)
- A joint feels loose or unstable → stop that drill; loose joints that day → skip the session (R9)

Session timeline

Pre core (~10 min) → add-ons by target → 1–2 warm-up sets → your session → post core (~4 min)
Add-ons only when your session's targets call for them; tightness after a session → foam rolling (R7)

v5 — S6, the biceps hold, back as a post add-on: palms pressing forward on the rack uprights or a doorway (catalogue rev 14)